Copyright Statement

The Fillius Jazz Archive at Hamilton College has made a reasonable effort to secure permission from the interviewees to make these materials available to the public. Use of these materials by other parties is subject to the fair use doctrine in United States copyright law (Title 17, Chapter 1, section 107), which states that use by “reproduction in copies or phonorecords or by any other means specified by that section [106 and 106A], for purposes such as criticism, comment, news reporting, teaching (including multiple copies for classroom use), scholarship, or research, is not an infringement of copyright."

Any use that does not fall within fair use must be cleared with the rights holder. For assistance in contacting the rights holder please contact the Fillius Jazz Archive, Hamilton College, 198 College Hill Road, Clinton, NY 13323 (phone: 315-859-4071).

Stefon Harris

Vibraphonist Stefon Harris' passionate artistry and virtuosity have propelled him to the forefront of the jazz scene. He has been called one of the most important artists in jazz by the L.A. Times *and he has earned four Grammy nominations and was chosen best vibes in 2017 and '18 by* DownBeat *magazine's Critics Poll. Michelle Reiser-Memmer hosted the event and participated in the audience Q&A.*

Stefon was interviewed via Zoom on November 11, 2020, by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: Welcome, Mr. Harris. It's a pleasure to see you.

SH: Likewise. Thank you for having me, I'm looking forward to our conversation today. It's always nice, under these circumstances, to communicate with people, whether it's in-person or over Zoom.

MR: Right. I mean normally I would — I give you a virtual handshake. I was lucky to see a preview of the concert that you filmed for Hamilton and I was very impressed first of all with the music, the interaction and the quality of it, so I appreciate and we appreciate you taking the time and effort to create the next best thing to being here. I wanted to read something from your website because I was saying to myself this video shows a very high standard when it comes to quality. This is what it said about Sonic Creed, a recent recording of yours. It says, "The album chronicles the story of people and their time on the planet, it's a reflection of African-American life in the late twentieth and early twenty-first centuries, and a sonic manifestation and creed of family, community and legacy." So I think it's safe to say that you set a very high bar for yourself and Blackout. Is that a fair statement?

SH: Absolutely, and bigger than the idea that I set the bar, these people on the wall all around me, I'm surrounded by incredible artists —

MR: Me too.

SH: You know every single day, from where I'm sitting at the piano or on the vibes, I'm writing and creating. I see a photo of Duke Ellington or whoever it is in my room and they remind me of the importance of staying focused on why art is important. Art is not important in our society because of the individual talent of an artist or an individual artist's ego. Art is important because it's a reflection of what's happening in the world right now. The reason that Herbie Hancock back there and Miles Davis, all these people became so incredible wasn't just their musicianship. It has more to do with the fact that they captured the essence of what was happening in the world at that time so that we gain a better understanding of how we got to the point that we're at now.

MR: I'm glad you said that, because it seems there is so much to reflect in the arts now, maybe just so many things that are happening all at the same time, yet over my shoulder are Lester Young and Count Basie, and incredible to think that their music at the time was probably eighty years ago. And do you feel that what they were doing carried as much significance to the community as what you are doing?

SH: Well that's a tough question because those are my heroes so I'm doing what I can to gain a seat next to them even if it's like twenty levels down. I just want to be as close to those icons as possible. But what I will say is, as we look at the development of our art form in this country, and we look at the effect of institutionalization on the art form. So when you're looking at Count Basie or Lester Young, this is before jazz was inside of conservatories and music programs. So the music was really primarily being generated from the community outward. So when you think about it, Count Basie, I don't think that there was much separation between his community here in Newark, and he's from Red Bank originally but Newark, New Jersey is where he spent a lot of time in addition to Kansas City, he was in the neighborhood with the people, uplifting people. So I think there was a deep sense of connection. And even when I think about Miles Davis and obviously he's a genius as an artist, but I think the social strength that we were experiencing as a nation in the late 60s and 70s, especially as an African-American, I think we were in a space where we needed to be able to stand up, just like James Brown said, "Say it loud/I'm black and I'm proud." And I think Miles Davis represented that, in all his intelligence, all of his elegance, all of his swagger. Like I'm not going to change who I am. I know that I'm beautiful and I'm going to lead with that. So their function in society was bigger than the notes. They really represented the communities from which they arose.

MR: Yeah. "Bigger than the notes" I like that.

SH: We try to do the same thing of course. And when I think about the music that we're creating I'm never picking a random song from the past because it sounds good to me. Everything on our current album is there because I had a real life experience with the composer where I've spent time with them and they've had some impact in my life. This album is about my family, my wife, it's about my brothers and sisters and what's happening right now.

MR: Well keeping a group of musicians together for seventeen years is quite an accomplishment. I mean keeping them together for seven days is sometimes impossible. We all do so many things. When you're working on a tune, perhaps in a rehearsal, and it's a composition of yours, how comfortable are you with — I'll use the word "instructing" or "suggesting" to your fellow musicians how to play? Or perhaps what not to play?

SH: That's another great question. I would tell you as an improviser I think our success is predicated upon three fundamental values. Those values are love, trust, and respect. When we walk into a room to learn a new piece of music we are leading with that. I never tell Terreon what to play on the drums. Never. There's no need because I've done it maybe twice over the course of the past seventeen years, and both times what I suggested was nowhere near the level of what he came up with on his own. And the same is true of Marc and Casey. So really when I'm composing it's not so much that I own the idea. I think of composition as not really a creative process, it's really a process of discovery. I spent the majority of my time, like a lot of musicians, working on my ear, working on my ability to perceive possibility. So when I sit it's not that something's already in my mind — I find it — oh that's how that works, oh this will fit there. So I've contributed that portion. When I bring it in to the other guys in the band, they're perceiving other parts of it that I can't see. And it's that conglomerate of imagination of intelligence, of informed diverse culture, that creates the magic that is jazz. What we make is so much bigger than what I could do on my own. It's really only possible if we have divergent perspectives, people who don't think the same way, people who disagree who come together. Magic lives in between those interesting spaces between disparate ideas.

MR: Yeah. I thought it was a marvelous — what I heard on the preview — a combination of something that was obviously arranged and written out, but then it veered off, came back, and what you're talking about, the equal contribution of all the players was very evident. I wanted to ask, this could be like minutiae, but I'm fascinated about musical decisions and orchestrations. There's a point, I believe it was in the first song which was fairly long. And there's a drum solo. And everybody in the band except the sax player is going [scats] followed by Terreon filling in and then another [scats]. And it happened a number of times. So why didn't the sax player go [scats]?

SH: I mean it's like one of those things that sometimes he'll do it, sometimes he won't. You never know. I mean the music is different every single time and it could have been a conscious decision on his part that he didn't feel that that texture was necessary, or he may have been thinking about something else. That's the interesting thing about this art form. It's really — I've heard Marc Cary describe it as much more of a practice. It's not so much that you are learning music in advance and then you're executing. The actual beauty of the art form is the practice of making music on stage. So we are doing jazz when we're there together so whatever level of engagement that you have is a manifestation of jazz. Whether it is to push forward with a strong idea to influence others, or to step back and give space for other people to shine. You know the other amazing thing about improvisation is the speed of thought. Things happen so quickly. It's actually much more connected to intuition, which I think is just a really fast form of thinking. But

you can't think through every step in advance. Because once the music goes this way it's highly likely it's not going to continue. You don't know what it's going to do. So if it pivots you have to constantly be listening and ready to go wherever the community, the team decides to go.

MR: I made note of the different sounds you got out of your group, the combination of marimba and bass in unison, and piano in unison, playing melody at the piano also. And I had a question about your improvising. Do you feel that because the marimba has very little sustain, do you think you improvise differently on the marimba than you do on the vibes?

SH: Oh wow that's interesting. You know I would say that as an improviser I feel more connected to the marimba because the marimba occupies a very unique frequency. So when I play the vibraphone its frequencies have a lot in common with the piano. So I may play a couple of notes and they may actually blend with the piano. So it actually doesn't stand out quite as much, whereas the marimba is such a unique frequency I can go out and hit a note really softly and it would still be really clear. And there's also something about the wood, that organic sound, that I find it to be more rhythmically articulate. And most of the phrasing is connected to rhythmic articulation. So I'm a little — it's interesting, I'm a little biased towards the marimba as an improviser. But I almost never play melodies on the marimba. I love the sound of the vibraphone, it's so gorgeous and lush, it's like this warm palette that just melts over the overall sound. So to play a melody on the vibraphone you can feel like you're inside of everything else that's happening around you. You feel deeply connected. And then when it's time to solo I dart over to the marimba. I love them both. And actually you'll notice on the video sometimes I'm playing them both at the same time.

MR: Well I had a thought, speaking of the fellows over my shoulder, that era of musician placed a huge amount of importance on being able to recognize people by their personal sound. So I have an opinion, and I'll be happy for you to tell me I'm wrong. And that is, I would — it seems to me that recognizing wind instruments, because of all the things that go into the sound — the reed, the breath, the diaphragm, the mouthpiece — would be somewhat easier than to identify vibes players because you have metal and a mallet. Do you want to give me your opinion on that?

SH: Well obviously there's a reason why there's not a really long lineage of great vibe players. It's a tough instrument. It's one of the easiest instruments to start with. I mean you basically walk up to the thing and you hit is and you get a note that's in tune. It's a little more complicated than that of course, but I think initially it's one of the easier instruments to start with, compared to a trumpet for example. But then the challenge is, because you don't have all these interesting levels of expression from the instrument

itself, you actually have to push more of your personal expression through the instrument to make your own voice. So you can hear Dexter Gordon, a single note and you know that it's Dexter Gordon or Lester Young. Whereas the vibraphone it's a little harder to tell from a single note, although touch has a lot to do with it. Some people, I play with a little bit — well I play with a wide range of touch but in general I have a little bit heavier touch than let's say Bobby Hutcherson who does a really light, sort of glassy touch so that the instrument sparkles almost. So you may notice a difference there. But mainly I think with the vibraphone it's about your note choices, right? And it's about how you phrase. So I tend to do a lot of — like I'll put two notes together so it's not [scats] not [scats]. A lot of [scats], there's a lot of those little embellishments. And then you hear Milt Jackson, his was more like [scats]. He would sort of take the independent notes and create melisma or embellishments that are kind of his style.

MR: Yeah. Speaking of Bobby Hutcherson, I wanted to make sure I thanked you — last night I was checking out some of your recordings and I said, I was sitting in my kitchen and I went, "Oh my God." And my wife goes, "What's the matter?" And I said, "Well Stefon did Bobby Hutcherson's song called 'Now.'" And I don't want to spend a lot of time on that but that song used to fascinate me. It was so beautiful. And so thank you for doing a version of it.

SH: Yeah. What a fantastic piece of music, and it functions in the exact way that you hope that any great piece of music will function in that it becomes this phenomenal platform for the expression of a myriad of voices. It's a so beautiful melody that it's repeated with an absolutely perfect harmony under it. But it just sort of breathes and it allows you to step into the middle of the song and sing your truth in your own way. It's a rare thing to come across a composition like that. And unfortunately that's not a piece that's very well known, but I think hopefully the Blackout recording will help. I think Bill Watrous did a recording of it and one or two other people are starting to do that too. It's definitely one of my favorites for the band to play because, because of the repeated melody it's not so much about one soloist at a time. It's really about us coming together under this repeated melody, how we continually change the texture around it. So playing that piece of music helps unite us as an ensemble and keeps us focused on our purpose.

MR: Yeah. Going back to the vibes for a minute I have this vision of you as a young man, you know before you could tell the venue what kind of vibes and marimba would be onstage for you, I was picturing yourself like going to a gig with the vibes, and the set-up of that is a bit of a chore, isn't it?

SH: Yes it is. I did it while I was young and in New York and then I said look if I ever have any level of success in this business I'm never moving one of these things again. So

generally when I travel I don't bring a vibraphone or a marimba, whatever is available for me that day I'll show up and play it.

MR: Right.

SH: I have the improviser's mindset so that I've shown up and there were cracked notes, but in the concert I'll use those notes. A note is just another sound that I can use in the process of improvisation. So — I remember playing with Joe Henderson and a couple of us in the band, Joe was going through a period where he was trying out a bunch of drummers. And on occasion he'd try someone who really didn't work out. So some of us were young, we were in the back and we were talking like, "Oh man, this guy messed up my solo, and I was trying to do this" and such and such. But Joe Henderson, night after night, it didn't matter who was on the stage, he was able to be magic, with unbelievable clarity regardless of the level of the other musicians around him. And in fact he elevated everyone else because when he started playing everybody else sounded better. So that's a great lesson I think I learned over the years from playing with Joe Henderson that it's never the instrument's fault.

MR: Okay.

SH: You can take that instrument in your right hand, they'll make magic with it.

MR: Okay. You mean I can't use that excuse anymore, huh? How would you like — music journalists and critics, their task often times is to review records and concerts. If you could ghost write a review of your own LP or CD or MP3, what would you say about your own music?

SH: That's a tough question. I mean I think the highest value that drives me is simply that music is one manifestation of empathy but I try to live a life with my family and how I maneuver through the world in general always being led through the values of empathy. But I hope that when people would hear my music that it's not just about me but you hear the community, you hear how these disparate voices are coming together to create something as incredibly beautiful that they wouldn't be able to do on their own. And on top of that I think it's really important that I be of service, right? Just like a chauffeur or a politician or a cook, we all have to provide some service to society. And I think the service that we're supposed to be providing as artists is we're supposed to be amplifying the voices of our community. Many parts of our community don't have the ability to articulate themselves. We have been studying for many years and are still working on the ability to articulate emotion in sound. So when someone hears my music I hope they hear the sound of the community that we come from, that they hear the beauty that lives in our community, the pluses, the minuses, the struggle. I hope that there's some documentation about what's happening in our world right now.

MR: Nice. I think you should write your own reviews. Getting back to improvising for a moment, when we play the saxophone or the trumpet we're not seeing the notes. We're knowing what key we put down, what we're going to get. Is there a sense of sight involved when you improvise? Because the whole thing is laid out in front of you and of course your ear is the main driver I would say, but what role does sight play?

SH: Well it's interesting. In many ways, of course I appreciate sight, but it's a distraction in a lot of ways because you can look down and you can see a shape and you can decide to play that shape but maybe that's not what the music is asking for. Music is really a science of sound. So the primary way that we should be receiving information is through our ear. So for me a lot of times, especially when I'm playing a ballad, when I'm live in concert what I tend to do is I stand up really straight when I'm playing a ballad and I find a point in the back of the room. Usually there's an exit sign that's red or something that you can see. And I'll just focus on that. And I've tried not to look down at my instrument at all, so that I'm focused more on hearing and feeling and then capturing the note that's in my ear first. Not that there's anything wrong with recognizing a pattern and playing that, but my ambition is to really continue to deepen my ability to see the world of sound through my ear. A great story is something that happened to me that really solidified my perspective is a couple of years ago I got a chance to play with Wayne Shorter and Herbie Hancock, we did this big gala and I was nervous of course. So the night before Don Beasley who was the musical director, he said, "Hey Stefon, do you want to write an arrangement on this tune?" I said, "Oh my goodness, of course." So I stayed up all night, I'm writing this arrangement and we had rehearsal the next day. I come into rehearsal and I had my little charts, and I go over to Herbie, you know, I go over to the bass player. And then when I go over to Wayne Shorter, I'm, "Mr. Shorter, here's the chart." Wayne just says, he's like, "Yeah, yeah, I don't read music. I stopped reading music like seventeen years ago." He was like, "Once my eyes got a little funny I just stopped." And I was just thinking oh my goodness, all this beautiful music this guy has been making for the last seventeen years has all come from his incredible ability to perceive using his ear, and that it just reminded me that what we have on paper is just drawings. It's not the actual lake. Right? You need to get out there and swim or do you want to focus on the painting? I think both are beautiful, but that was a pivotal moment for me and it reminded me that I really need to continue to develop my empathy, my ability to perceive what's happening around me. So I would tell you probably 98 percent of the time that I'm dealing with music trying to learn, I sing — I practice solfeggio and I'm at the piano, I almost never practice at the vibes at this point. Because it's very physical and I have a lot of muscle memory from over the years. But it's a lot of singing, away from any instrument, just to develop my ear.

MR: If we decided that we wanted to commission a new work from you and your group, is there a process that you engage in to get started?

SH: Wow. You know it's interesting, I'm learning as an educator I'm currently a professor at Rutgers University in Newark, New Jersey. And this semester I started working with a group of students who are really at the very beginning, who don't really play instruments, and so I'm starting to focus on how do we put art in the hands of the general population, not just elite musicians. I think everybody deserves the right to experience the lesson that is creative art. So I've been focusing on that a lot. And it's been really interesting because I'll be working with the students on a really basic concept and then that simple concept will reveal a fascinating piece of music. So I just write whatever is available to me. So if I were commissioned, I couldn't tell you in advance. I'd have to say okay, here's some space and I'm ready to create, I have energy, like I know that there's something that's inside of me. And then I'd have to just step back and be patient. Usually it takes me about two weeks before I get the momentum going. I'll get up in the morning, first thing I'll do is go right to a piano and I'll pluck at a couple of random notes. And if in fifteen minutes I don't really get anything that's cool, I'll just walk away and do something else. It's not there. And then some mornings you go right to the piano and you play a couple of notes and you say, "Oh my goodness, that's it." And then I can spend the next twenty hours trying to find ways to contextualize that beautiful little gem that I found. I didn't create it, I found it. And then I'm just surrounding it with interesting things trying to utilize my knowledge of harmony to give an emotional springboard to the melody.

MR: Yeah. Do you ever find any little gems when you're driving in your car or taking a walk and then like — oh I've got to write this down somehow?

SH: Yeah. It can happen at any moment. And it can happen in any form too. Sometimes it's a collection of words that come to mind that turn into music. So on this concert, this video, we did a piece called "Let's Take a Trip to the Sky" which is a piece that I wrote for my wife. I was on tour on one of our major anniversaries and I missed it, and I was thinking about her, and I just started to write down some thoughts about, I've been married twenty years now. So I started to write down some thoughts about what is it that we need to do to ensure that our love continues to grow and that it stays strong and just how much I cared about her. And I wrote that down, no instrument around just in a hotel room thinking about life. And then when I got home I put those words on the piano and just started to look at the emotion of every word and look for a chord that captured the feeling of the word. Well that inspiration didn't come from an instrument or notes at all, it came from my dedication or love for my wife.

MR: Beautiful story. This question would be something I would normally ask pre-Covid. Because a lot of questions are not even worth asking at this point. But let's say last July I

was able to ask you this question. And that is, with your students or someone looking for advice, a young up and coming musician, do you have anything that you can tell them that you think is worthwhile for them to constantly pay attention to as they try to build a career?

SH: Well it's an interesting angle because my take on it is that it's about service and remembering that we're no more important than any other profession out here. We have to provide service to society at large. You have to wrap your head around what is it that you're providing and who is it that you want to be of service to. Once you can see that it becomes increasingly clear how you want to present yourself. The idea that I want to be a star or something is such an abstract concept, and you end up chasing a pipeline that's probably from the past, and it's probably a losing battle. Most people who rise to the top rise to the top because of authentic artistic expression. Really, it's just like movies or sports. I mean my wife used to work for the Nets and Devils so we had season passes and free games. And I always remember loving going to the Nets game because it would start with a big announcement, "And now, your, New Jersey Nets." Right? And the crowd would go nuts and people were like we're doing so great, did you see we just dunked and man wait, you're eating popcorn but somehow you're sitting there and you see your own ambition represented in what is happening. I'm a boxing fan, I like basketball, and I remember being a kid and watching Michael Jordan play on television when he had the flu. And I'm thinking oh my goodness, this guy is like making every shot and he's going over and he's sick, he's laying down, he gets back up. And I just remember being in high school thinking yeah, like I want that. I think I have that kind of drive in me and if he can do it I'm going to push myself to do it. So as an artist you really need — people are going to come to you because they see a bit of themselves in the art that it is that you're creating. Not because you're so smart or so creative. It's because you make them feel alive in ways that they're not able to express on their own. So service first and foremost. And then the commerce part I think when you really have a clear sense of who you're serving, it becomes easier. It's never easy, but you know, I never create with money in mind. I first create authentically from the bottom of the heart, and then I look around and I say well where is this piece of art relevant? And it's not always relevant in a jazz club or on a concert hall. So for me, I've been teaching in corporate settings, doing corporate leadership training in addition to developing apps, and it's that I don't view myself as a musician, one manifestation of my talent happens to be music. But that can be manifested to be of service in a myriad of ways.

MR: Well that's really interesting because was it a conscious decision, let's say most young musicians go through struggles trying to make a living. Did you say to yourself I need to do other things as well as play mallet instruments if I want to create a career for myself?

SH: No I didn't. I don't think I ever went through that type of clarity when I was very, very young. I mean I just love music. I mean I still — I'm more energized, I work harder now than I ever have in my entire life and I have so much joy and passion for music. And I think that authenticity was infectious ever since I was a little kid in sixth grade playing an instrument I just led with so much happiness and also wanting to share and connect with people in vulnerability. And I think we're at a point in our society where that's something that's hard to come by and people perceive vulnerability. And then when I think about making a living, I remember years ago, this is I was already touring but I remember having a conversation with a group of musicians and I was saying how well if you want to think about money there's nothing wrong with that, but out of all the options in the world right now you're choosing jazz if it's about money? I'm not so sure that's the best decision. And I reached a point where I said okay, well I didn't have kids at the time but I want to have kids one day and I want to be able to provide the best that I can for my children and I need to think more about money so I started to read some books about real estate and investing and other things. So when I think about money I start to think about the concept of ownership, creating something that can be a commodity that can be sold. I never think about money as it relates to my music or the vibraphone. I like to keep it separate. Whether if I were a billionaire I would still practice just as much. I'm not motivated by money. For me.

MR: I wish I could remember which musician said, "Yeah jazz is a great field, you can become a hundredaire." So I'm going to ask you probably a tough question, then we'll see if we have any questions from other people who are viewing. Do you have anything that you'd like to reflect on and say about the current situation the United States is in?

SH: I look back, prior to our current administration, and I think what's at the center of what brought us to this situation is a lack of empathy. I'm going to always go back to empathy. And I should preface it by saying that I don't think that empathy has morality. Empathy is not good or bad, empathy has been used for evil throughout history, and it's been used for good. The most important thing though is to be able to quiet the ego first and to listen and to understand the environment in which your ideas exist. And I think what was occurring in our country was that we weren't listening to each other. You know people on the left, people in the middle, were totally shocked by one another. We're not paying attention to who we are and we're not getting to the root of what we really care about because we're focused on this right or wrong, this projection of right or wrong is an egocentric perspective. So for me if there's anything I hope to contribute to this world is I want to amplify the value, the understanding of the value of empathy, getting people to say, I always like to say when I'm teaching about empathy is that it doesn't matter what you think. It's just irrelevant. Right? Right now you should be just trying to understand

the person in front of you. No judgement at all. Then once it's there then you can have some sense of judgement in whichever way you choose. And then it's up to your moral code. It's about how you will behave. But I don't think we're in a situation right now where we have been paying attention to one another. And it's been great, honestly, to see president-elect Biden use the word empathy as much as he does because I think that's what's going to need to happen to get the gears of our Congress working properly.

MR: Well thank you for sharing that. So Michelle do we have any folks who would like to ask something of Mr. Harris?

MRM: We have two questions. One is, "Are your improvisational substantially influenced by your current emotions or are you able to compartmentalize the two?

SH: Wow.

MRM: What a question.

SH: Well you know that's a great question. And on the one hand most people would say no, no it's about how you're feeling, you know, that day. But I find that what happens for me is I may be backstage feeling one way, and then once I step out on stage if I'm humble and ready to receive the possibilities I lose myself and I start to react to whatever the emotions are that are around me, so like the audience, I'm actually on the journey as well. And I don't know what it's going to be in advance. So for me to receive the beauty created by these iconic artists I actually have to quiet my own ego, which is not easy to do. I try to meditate before I go onstage and get the right mindset. But then I just experience the emotion that is there.

MR: Yeah. That is a really good question. I had a brief conversation with a student about it the other day and he said, "When I'm improvising I'm playing the way I feel." And sometimes practically you can't do that all the time. If you're going out and presenting something to a group of people and you're really down in the dumps, you still have to play for the people who are listening to you. At least that's my thought on that.

SH: It's that interesting dynamic. I mean of course we're all individuals and it's beautiful, and you're required to have your own perspective, but really we should be playing the way that we feel. Right? Like the way you're going to be successful is the audience has to feel alive. They have to feel amplified by what it is that you're doing. For you to just play, that you feel this way, if the audience feels a different way they're probably going to be frustrated. It's not about me.

MR: All right, Michelle, you have another one?

MRM: We have two more, they're both about improv. Another one is how would you describe your process of improv? How does jazz improv work?

SH: Well so much of jazz improvisation is directly connected to language for me. When I'm improvising I'm literally speaking in the exact same way that I'm speaking right now. I

just take the words away. So all the rhythms, all the nuances are here. The way that I speak is exactly the way that I play [scats]. I can take [scats] everything I say [scats] and play it on an instrument [scats]. Right? So the type of flow that I have when we're communicating right now is the same type of flow that I want to have when I'm onstage. Now the challenge is we're using language all the time and most of the time we're more comfortable speaking than we are playing. The language of harmony is so — it's not complex it's just a lot. So I spend the majority of my time working on my ear and learning little tiny bits of vocabulary so that whatever it is I hear I can react to it. So the goal ultimately is to not know. Right? It's like I almost want to forget everything that I'm learning and I hope that one day I can get to that and just say I don't need to know what the song is, let's just play. And you can just hear and react. I'm not there, I've got a long way to go, but that keeps me hungry. But again, at the center of great improvisation I still think it's being able to understand that your idea comes to life relative to what's happening around you. You can take a single note and you just go [gestures] right at the right moment and it's just, man, the whole audience will start clapping. And it's just like one note, it's not even a special note, its placement and timing relative to everyone else.

MR: Yes. And as you notably said in your TED talk, when you play an F sharp over an F chord you better know how to work with that. Okay Michelle.

MRM: One more question and this might be the last one that has come in, it says can you speak to the relationship between improvisation and composition? What about the cultural politics of that distinction?

SH: I mean I honestly think of composition as just really really slow improvisation. It's the same idea. It's just that when you're improvising it's happening quickly. But fundamentally I don't see it as the idea that I own the music, that I'm so special, that I'm creating something. I will literally go [scats] and go no that's not it, I don't know why that's not it. Then go [scats] oh that's it. In my mind the reason that I know that that's the right note is that it already exists. There are these beautiful — I also love physics, love science and I find that there are, in theory there is this beautiful logic that governs the behavior of all being, whether from plants — there's some logic that holds everything together. And what's happening to me is the more I study the more I bring to mind, I'm able to see those natural connections that exist. Not that I'm creating them. But the more perceptive I become the easier it is to capture the music that's there.

MR: Those are good questions. We've put some difficult inquiries to you today and I appreciate your thoughtfulness. We could wrap up shortly. There was one thing I wanted to get in, this is when I listened to your first selection on the preview I had this phrase that has been coming up. And it has to do mostly with current jazz or in the last let's say twenty years. The difference between playing the time and playing with the time. Playing

with the time. And I guess I thought that for a while everybody in your group was playing with the time. Am I anywhere close to being with my observation —

SH: Well no, no. It's an interesting perspective that you're bringing up because there is a significant faction of the young jazz world that is playing with the time, for the past two decades or whatever. You've had all these songs in 13-1/2 [over] 8 for fifty odd measures and performed this experiment, and there's nothing wrong with that. But I think Blackout, our band, we don't come from that perspective at all. If something ends up in an odd meter it's because it revealed itself that way. It makes you always feel good — the way that I think time works for me is definitely with a cultural quality. My mother is a minister. I grew up in the black church. And I remember someone just standing up and just saying, you know "I want to thank you because last week you prayed for my brother and he was sick and I want to let you know he's feeling better." Bang, then the choir would come in just out of nowhere. And then they would start speaking but they would start using pitches, right? So [sings] "I just wanted to let you know" and the choir would come in. So all the phrasing was completely part of the whole, connected to authentic expression. Now was it right on the beat? Behind the beat? I don't think that that's relevant. What makes music feel good is first and foremost your internal coordination. So I could take any phrase, it doesn't matter, and play it in the complete wrong spot, and if my internal coordination is strong enough it's going to feel good. So it's that kind of thing that is not an intentional, okay we're going to try this complex pattern. Again, nothing wrong with that but that's not where we were coming from. We're really trying to testify from the heart of the spirit. And I think that's what's in the hearts and minds of our feelings.

MR: Well this has been a fascinating conversation. Thanks, Michelle for setting it up and again, the video you provided us with is really wonderful. I can't wait to see the complete program and that someday down the road we'll see you in person.

SH: And I want to add one thing about the video process, much like the process of creating music. You never want to try to recreate something. That's sort of a losing battle. Charlie Parker was really good. He did a great job of documenting the world that he inhabited. So when I tried to figure out well what's the next step given this pandemic I said well let's not try to recreate a live experience. But what we want to do is take a look at the format that we're utilizing and look at the assets of that format and highlight those. So I think what was really exciting was we took a lot of time to prepare was utilizing video editing. So when you're live you're sitting in one space in a concert hall, there's so much going on that you can't think. But you have one perspective. So we focused a lot on cutting camera angles right at the moment when something interesting happened in the music so you hear it and you get a visual cue. But the experience is totally different than live. But I

find it to be really different — I find it to be really insightful. I learned more about what's happening in the music as a viewer in the video platform than I do live. When it's live I feel more the whole thing. But in this someone doing something interesting, and an attack over there and things that I wouldn't always catch.

MR: Yeah. There was a couple of moments where people's expressions were so in tune with some sound that happened. That's like great. You know, that look that musicians get. And to capture that that's way cool.

MRM: So a word about the video is that as you may know Stefon Harris and Blackout were scheduled to perform live at Hamilton College in Wellin Hall last April and that did not happen. So we were lucky enough to be able to ask them to record the entire band got together at Rutgers University and that video will be available for three days starting on Friday the 13th at 7:30 P.M. You can go to Hamilton.edu/performing arts for a link. And I'm so happy that we were able to create that for our viewers. It's free to watch and also free to share with your friends because we'd like the whole world to see it for the three days that it's available.

MR: Excellent.

SH: Thank you for the work you're doing to keep the music alive and it really is something that we all need right now.

MRM: Thank you, I would agree. And thank you for the work that you're doing to keep the music alive. So I think we're out of time. This goes until 12:50, we have students maybe who need to get back to class and people that need to get back to their desks. So thank you very much, Monk and Stefon for taking the time to talk to each other and to let us listen in. It was fantastic. I feel like I've learned so much in this hour. So thank you and enjoy the rest of your day, enjoy your weekend and be well.

MR: Okay thank you. Over and out.